Topic 7 — Indian Theatre & Performing Arts

Covers syllabus (click to expand)

Indian Theatre | Performing Arts | Folk Theatre | Sanskrit Theatre | Natyashastra | Rangmanch (Stage Traditions) | Kathputli | Shadow Puppetry | String Puppetry

Sources: NCERT An Introduction to Indian Art (Class 11), Natyashastra, UNESCO ICH, SNA/NSD
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Current Affairs

- **Koodiyattam** (कूड़ियाट्टम्) was proclaimed a UNESCO masterpiece in **2001** and entered the Representative List in **2008**.
- **Ramlila** (रामलीला) entered UNESCO ICH in **2008**.
- **Mudiyettu** (मुडियेट्टु) of Kerala entered UNESCO ICH in **2010**. It is ritual theatre, not Kathakali.

7.1 Indian Theatre

Indian theatre is live drama with speech, song, dance, and costume. The three layers are Sanskrit, folk, and modern.

- It is the oldest continuous drama tradition in the subcontinent. Vedic *samvada* hymns are only a hint, not full plays.
- The word *nataka* is from *nata*, meaning dancer. Drama, dance and music start as one art.
- The oldest rock-cut theatre in India is **Sitabenga Cave** (Ramgarh hills, Surguja, Chhattisgarh), while neighbouring **Jogimara** preserves early frescoes.
- The codifier is **Natyashastra** by **Bharata Muni**. It lists about **10 rupaka** and **9 rasa**.
- Temple Sanskrit theatre survived in Kerala's **koothambalam** halls through **Koodiyattam**.
- Mughal and British rule broke the Sanskrit temple-palace loop; theatre survived as **folk drama** (nautanki, jatra, bhavai, yakshagana).
- Modern proscenium theatre emerged from the mid-19th century onward, championed in Hindi literature by **Bhartendu Harishchandra** of Banaras (UP).
- Parsi theatre was commercial, melodramatic, and popular in cities.
- **Indra Sabha**, composed by **Agha Hasan Amanat** and performed at **Lucknow in 1853**, is the milestone Urdu-Awadhi musical play patronized by the court of Awadh.
- IPTA was founded in **1943** (Bengal famine, anti-fascist, leftist).
- The **National School of Drama (NSD)** was founded in **1959** at New Delhi, hosting the annual Bharat Rang Mahotsav; it was shaped into premier prominence under long-serving director **Ebrahim Alkazi**.
- **Badal Sircar** is linked to Third Theatre (street, no proscenium).

- Sangeet Natak Akademi was founded in **1952** at New Delhi as the apex body for music, dance, and theatre.
- Classical Sanskrit plays invariably end happily (there is no Greek-style tragedy tradition).
- Stock figures include the **nayaka** (hero), **nayika** (heroine), and **vidushaka** (jester/clown), while the **sutradhara** serves as the stage manager and director-presenter.

> **Logic:** Theatre is not “only Sanskrit.” UPPCS geography loves **Nautanki** as **Uttar Pradesh.

7.2 Performing Arts

Performing arts are live arts before an audience. The set is music, dance, theatre, and puppetry.

- *Sangeet* is gita, vadya, and nritya. This chapter facts **theatre, puppetry and stage**.
- Folk “total shows” mix all three: Nautanki, Yakshagana, Jatra, Tamasha.
- The temple cluster is Koodiyattam, Bhagavata Mela (TN), and theyyam/mudiyettu as ritual theatre.
- The street cluster is puppets and bahurupi.
- Trap: SNA is not a dance-only body.

> **Logic:** Koodiyattam is **theatre**, not a ninth SNA classical dance.

7.3 Folk Theatre

Folk theatre uses a regional language. It is open-air, oral, and tied to a festival or fair.

- **Nautanki** (नौटंकी) belongs to **Uttar Pradesh** (उत्तर प्रदेश). It is folk opera and an offshoot of Swang. It is named in **Ain-i-Akbari**.
- The Nautanki drum is **nagara** (नगाड़ा). Two schools are **Kanpur** and **Lucknow**.
- **Ramlila** (रामलीला) belongs to **UP** (Ramnagar–Varanasi, Braj). It is for Dussehra and is UNESCO **2008** (proclaimed 2005). Traditionally men play Sita too.
- **Raslila** (रासलीला) is the **Braj / Mathura–Vrindavan** Krishna play. Manipuri Ras Lila is classical dance of Manipur, not this Braj folk play.
- **Swang** (स्वांग) belongs to Haryana, western **UP**, and Rajasthan. It is satire. Men play women.
- **Jatra** (यात्रा) belongs to Bengal and Odisha. It is open-air, and Chaitanya used it for Krishna-bhakti. The Odisha street variant is **Sahi Jatra** (साही यात्रा).
- **Tamasha** (तमाशा) belongs to Maharashtra. It uses **Lavani** (लावणी). **Women even play male roles** (opposite of Swang).
- **Yakshagana** (यक्षगान) belongs to coastal **Karnataka**. It is all-night, on Vijayanagara court soil, and in Kannada.
- **Bhavai** (भवई) belongs to Gujarat (Kutch–Kathiawar). It uses vesha/swanga skits. The sutradhara is called **Nayaka**.
- **Bhand Pather** (भांड पाथर) belongs to Kashmir. It is satire. Muslim performers tell secular stories.

- **Maach** (माच) belongs to Malwa / Ujjain, MP. Couplets are called *rangat doha*.
- **Therukoothu** (तेरुक्कूत्तु) is Tamil Nadu street theatre.
- **Dashavatar** (दशावतार) belongs to Konkan (Sindhudurg–Goa). It presents ten Vishnu avatars.
- **Ankiya Nat** (अंकिया नाट) belongs to Assam and is linked to **Sankaradeva** (शंकरदेव). It is one-act and uses masks. Musicians are Gayan–Bayan (khol).
- **Bhaona** (भाओना) is the dramatic staging of Srimanta Sankaradeva's Ankiya Nat, traditionally preserved and enacted in the Vaishnavite satras of **Majuli Island** in Assam.
- **Mudiyettu** (मुडियेट्टु) is Kerala ritual theatre. It is UNESCO **2010**. It is not Kathakali.
- **Ramman** (रम्माण) belongs to Garhwal, Uttarakhand. It honours **Bhumiyal Devta** (भूमियाल देवता) and is UNESCO ICH **2009**.
- It is village ritual theatre with masks, music, and seasonal performance — not a commercial stage play and not SNA classical dance.
- Do not equate Ramman with **Ramlila** of the plains or with **Koodiyattam** (कूड़ियाट्टम्) of Kerala.
- **Oja-Pali** (ओजा-पाली) belongs to Assam. It is a Manasa / serpent-goddess narrative. Oja is the lead and Pali is the chorus.
- **Powada** (पोवाड़ा) belongs to Maharashtra. It is a Shivaji ballad-opera. Singers are Shahir / Gondhali.
- **Kariyila** (करियला) is Himachal open-air night skits.
- **Daskathia** (दाशकठिया) belongs to Odisha. Two narrators (Gayaka and Palia) use *kathia* clappers.
- **Naqal / Bhand** (नक़ल / भांड) belongs to Punjab. It is Behroopiya mimicry by two artists.
- **Burrakatha** (बुराकथा) belongs to Andhra. It is named from the *burra* drum. It has one narrator and two chorus.
- **Villu Pattu** (विल्लुपाट्टु) is Tamil bow-song Ramayana.
- **Krishnattam** (कृष्णाट्टम्) belongs to Kerala. It is an eight-night Krishna cycle. It is not Kathakali.
- **Ottamthullal** (ओट्टमथुल्लल) belongs to Kerala. It is linked to **Kunchan Nambiar** (कुंचन नंबियार). It is solo satirical dance-theatre.
- **Bidesiya** (बिदेसिया) is by **Bhikhari Thakur** (भिखारी ठाकुर). It belongs to the Bhojpuri belt (Bihar / eastern **UP**). It is a migrant-labour play.
- **Pandavani** (पांडवानी) belongs to Chhattisgarh. It tells the Mahabharata. **Teejan Bai** (तीजन बाई) is linked to it.
- **Khyal** (ख्याल) is a Rajasthan folk play. It is not Hindustani *khayal* (ख्याल) singing.
- **Theyyam** (तैय्यम) is north Kerala ritual theatre. It holds Sangam Velan memory. It is not Kathakali.

> **Logic:** Nautanki belongs to **Uttar Pradesh. Tamasha is not UP. Yakshagana belongs to Karnataka, not Kerala.

7.4 Sanskrit Theatre

Sanskrit theatre uses Sanskrit and Prakrit. It runs roughly from the second century BCE to the twelfth century CE. The living remnant is **Koodiyattam**.

Playwrights (one name, one play fact)

- **Ashvaghosha** (अश्वघोष) wrote *Sariputraprakarana* (शारिपुत्रप्रकरण). It is often tagged the **first** classical Sanskrit play (Buddhist).
- **Bhasa** (भास) is among the earliest Sanskrit dramatists, with 13 surviving plays including masterpieces like *Svapnavasavadattam* (स्वप्नवासवदत्तम्) and the tragic hero drama *Urubhanga* (ऊरुभंग).
- **Kalidasa** (कालिदास) wrote three master plays: *Abhijnanashakuntalam* (अभिज्ञानशाकुन्तलम्), *Malavikagnimitram* (मालविकाग्निमित्रम्), and *Vikramorvashiya* (विक्रमोर्वशीयम्).
- Kalidasa poems that are **not** dramas are *Meghaduta* (मेघदूत), *Raghuvamsha* (रघुवंश), *Kumarasambhava* (कुमारसंभव), and *Ritusamhara* (ऋतुसंहार).
- *Shringara Shataka* (शृंगार शतक) belongs to **Bhartrihari** (भर्तृहरि), not Kalidasa.
- **Shudraka** (शूद्रक) wrote *Mrichchhakatika* (मृच्छकटिकम्) (The Little Clay Cart — social prakarana).
- **Vishakhadatta** (विशाखदत्त) wrote *Mudrarakshasa* (मुद्राराक्षस) (political thriller with Chanakya) and *Devichandraguptam* (देवीचन्द्रगुप्तम्).
- **Bhavabhuti** (भवभूति) wrote *Uttararamacharita* (उत्तररामचरित) (Karuna rasa peak), *Malatimadhava* (मालतीमाधव), and *Mahaviracharita* (महावीरचरित).
- King **Harsha** (हर्ष) (7th century CE) authored three Sanskrit plays: *Ratnavali* (रत्नावली), *Priyadarshika* (प्रियदर्शिका), and *Nagananda* (नागानन्द). *Ratnavali* contains one of the earliest vivid literary depictions of the celebration of **Holi** (होली).
- **Mahendravarman I** (महेन्द्रवर्मन प्रथम) wrote *Mattavilasa Prahasana* (मत्तविलास प्रहसन) (Pallava satire). He is the same king as the rock-cut Mandagapattu caves.

Conventions

- Elite speech is Sanskrit. Women, clowns, and servants speak **Prakrit**.
- **Natyadharmi** is stylised. **Lokadharmi** is closer to life.
- Classical Sanskrit used **curtains, not masks**. Kathakali *chutti* (चुट्टी) makeup is dance-drama, not this Sanskrit stage.
- **Koodiyattam / Kutiyattam** belongs to Kerala. It is the oldest *living* Sanskrit theatre, staged in a *Koothambalam*. One act can last days.
- Koodiyattam castes are **Chakyar** (चाक्यार) (actors) and **Nambiar** (drums). The drum is **mizhavu**. Opening recall is **nirvahana**.
- Koodiyattam UNESCO tags are masterpiece **2001** and Representative List **2008**.
- Sanskrit theatre declined as language left the masses and courts shifted. It survives as Koodiyattam, not as a north-Indian court play.

> **Logic:** Kalidasa's **plays** are three. *Uttararamacharita* (उत्तररामचरित) is by Bhavabhuti (भवभूति). *Mrichchhakatika* (मृच्छकटिकम्) is by Shudraka (शूद्रक).

7.5 Natyashastra

The **Natyashastra** is by **Bharata Muni**. It is a treatise of drama, dance, and music. Dance chapters use the same book.

- It is called a **Natyaveda** / fifth Veda in tradition.
- Pathya (words) is from **Rigveda** (ऋग्वेद).
- Gita (song) is from **Samaveda** (सामवेद).
- Abhinaya (acting) is from **Yajurveda** (यजुर्वेद).
- Rasa is from **Atharvaveda** (अथर्ववेद).
- The usual date band is **c. 200 BCE – 200 CE**. It is not Panini. It is not Kalidasa.
- Four abhinaya are **angika, vachika, aharya, sattvika**.
- The nine rasas are Shringara, Hasya, Karuna, Raudra, Veera, Bhayanaka, Bibhatsa, Adbhuta, and **Shanta** (later ninth).
- **Bhava** (भाव) is what the actor holds. **Rasa** is what the spectator tastes.
- The definitive medieval philosophical commentary on the *Natyashastra* is the *Abhinavabharati* by the Kashmiri Shaivite scholar **Abhinavagupta** (अभिनवगुप्त).
- The later digest is **Dhananjaya** (धनंजय), *Dasharupaka*.
- There are ten *rupakas*. Natyashastra itself leans on **Nataka** and **Prakarana**. Learn all ten names:

1. **Nataka** (नाटक) is a mythic hero play and is longer.
2. **Prakarana** (प्रकरण) is an invented social plot.
3. **Samavakara** (समवकार) is one of the ten rupakas.
4. **Ihamrga** (ईहामृग) is one of the ten rupakas.
5. **Dima** (डिम) is one of the ten rupakas.
6. **Vyayoga** (व्यायोग) is one of the ten rupakas.
7. **Anka / Utsrishtikanka** (अंक / उत्सृष्टिकांक) is one of the ten rupakas.
8. **Prahasana** (प्रहसन) is farce.
9. **Bhana** (भाण) is a monologue.
10. **Vithi** (वीथी) is one of the ten rupakas.

- **Purvaranga** (पूर्वरंग) is the ritual prelude (often behind the curtain). Then the sutradhara in white announces time and place.
- There is a happy-ending rule. The protagonist is male in the classical formula.
- The classical stage idea is lower floor = earth, upper = gods. Masks are not part of this grammar.

> **Logic:** Bharata is Natyashastra. Shanta is the ninth rasa in later lists.

7.6 Rangmanch (Stage Traditions)

Rangmanch is how the play is housed and how the audience enters.

- **Yavanika** (यवनिका) is the curtain. It is used for entries and exits.

- **Nepathya** (नेपथ्य) is backstage (dress, props).
- **Rangapitha / rangashirsha** (रंगपीठ / रंगशीर्ष) is the acting platform.
- **Mattavarani** (मत्तवारणी) are side platforms in the classical plan.
- **Natyagriha** (नाट्यगृह) is the theatre building.
- **Sitabenga** (सीताबेंगा) is in the Ramgarh hills. It is the earliest Indian amphitheatre fact.
- **Koothambalam** (कूथम्बलम्) is the Kerala temple theatre for Koodiyattam. It is not a gopuram.
- Folk rangmanch is often a **ground, mela, or temporary mandap**. No yavanika is needed.
- Ramnagar Ramlila uses the **town as stage** (moving audience).
- The modern fact is **NSD**, New Delhi, **1959**.
- **Prithvi Theatre** is in Mumbai (Kapoor). It is not NSD.
- **Naya Theatre** is linked to Habib Tanvir. Folk actors appear on the modern stage.

> **Logic:** Yavanika is not nepathya. Koothambalam is Kerala, not UP.

7.7 Puppetry

The four Indian puppet types are **string**, **shadow**, **rod**, and **glove**. Syllabus names the first two plus Kathputli (a string school).

String (sutradharika)

- Sutradhara literally means **holder of strings**. Puppet and play-director share the word.
- **Kathputli** (कठपुतली) belongs to **Rajasthan** (थार). They are wooden marionettes with bright dress and **no legs** (skirt hides the base). They are **not** UP.
- **Kundhei** (कुंधेई) is Odisha string. It uses light wood and is jointed.
- **Gombeyatta** (गोम्बेयट्ट) is Karnataka string (Yakshagana look).
- **Bommalattam** (बोम्मलाट्टम्) belongs to Tamil Nadu. It is a string and rod mix.

Shadow (chhaya / छाया)

- They are leather figures used with a lamp and screen. They have a flat profile.
- **Tholu Bommalata** (तोलू बोम्मलता) belongs to Andhra / Telangana. It uses large coloured leather.
- **Ravana Chhaya** (रावण छाया) belongs to Odisha. It uses deer-skin for the Ramayana. Figures stay mostly black.
- **Togalu Gombeyatta** (तोगलू गोम्बेयट्ट) is Karnataka shadow.
- **Tolpavakoothu** (तोलपावकूत्तु) belongs to Kerala. It is temple leather for the Kamba Ramayana.

Rod and glove (extras)

- **Yampuri** (यमपुरी) are Bihar rod puppets. They have no legs.
- **Putul Nach** (पुतुल नाच) is Bengal rod.
- **Pavakathakali / Pavakoothu** (पावकथकली / पावकूत्तु) is Kerala glove.

- **Gulabo–Sitabo** (गुलाबो-सीताबो) is a traditional glove puppetry form from **Lucknow (UP)** featuring witty domestic satirical dialogues between two women. It is native to Uttar Pradesh, distinct from Rajasthan's string Kathputli.

> **Logic:** Kathputli is **Rajasthan string**. Shadow is not Kathputli. Gulabo-Sitabo is **Lucknow glove**.
